

The birth chart, stripped to the degree.

A first step to understanding your own chart.

— I —

What a birth chart actually is

A map, not a verdict.

A birth chart is a map of the sky at the exact minute you were born, seen from the exact place you were born.

That's why the three details matter:

- **Date** tells us where the planets were.
- **Time** tells us which sign was rising on the eastern horizon, and how the twelve houses fall. Born just a few minutes later on the same day, you would have a completely different chart.
- **Place** tells us from where on Earth we're looking up, so it also sets the houses.

Your chart isn't a verdict. It's a description of the forces you work with: what drives you, how you go about it, where in life it shows up, and which parts of you argue with each other.

The whole method in one line: Planet = **what** · Sign = **how** · House = **where** · Aspect = **how they talk to each other** · Degree = **which shape it takes.**

Everything on the next pages unpacks that line. Most astrology stops before the last part. We don't.

— II —

How to read the wheel

Signs, houses, planets and four points.

Open any chart and you see a circle. Three layers sit on top of each other:

1. **The outer ring: the twelve signs.** Aries to Pisces, each 30° wide. Together they make 360°.
2. **The inner wedges: the twelve houses.** Twelve areas of life, numbered counter-clockwise, starting on the left.
3. **The symbols inside: the planets.** Where a planet sits tells you its sign (outer ring) and its house (inner wedge).

Four points hold the wheel together:

- **Ascendant (AC)**, far left: the sign rising at your birth. How you approach life and how others first experience you. It's the start of the 1st house.
- **Descendant (DC)**, far right, opposite the AC: what you look for in others, and what you meet in close partnership. Start of the 7th house.
- **Midheaven (MC)**, at the top: direction, career, public role. Start of the 10th house.
- **IC**, at the bottom: roots, home, where you come from. Start of the 4th house.

Tip: Think of the wheel as one day. Left is sunrise, top is noon, right is sunset, bottom is midnight. A Sun near the top means a birth around midday.

— III —

Planets: the WHAT

The actors.

Planets are the actors. Each one stands for a drive, a need, a part of you.

Planet	What it stands for
Sun	Who you're becoming. Your core purpose, what makes you feel alive.
Moon	What you need to feel safe. Emotional habits, what you learned early.
Mercury	How you think, learn and talk.
Venus	What you value and find beautiful. How you attract and relate.
Mars	How you go after what you want. Drive, anger, courage.
Jupiter	Where you grow, trust and expand. Meaning and belief.
Saturn	Where you meet limits, take responsibility and build what lasts.
Uranus	Where you break the rules to become yourself.
Neptune	Where you dream, long for more and lose your edges.
Pluto	Where you meet power, control and deep change.

Sun, Moon, Mercury, Venus and Mars move fast: they make **you** personal. Uranus, Neptune and Pluto move so slowly that a whole generation shares their sign. Standard astrology stops there: for the slow planets, it reads the house and calls the sign "generational".

We go further. Every planet sits on one exact degree, and each degree has its own theme. Together with its house, its aspects and the degrees of the planets it aspects, that flavours Pluto very specifically. More on degrees on page 8.

— IV —

Signs: the HOW

The style.

A sign colours a planet. Mars in Aries charges in. Mars in Libra negotiates first. Same drive, different style.

Four elements: the temperament

- **Fire** (Aries, Leo, Sagittarius): acts on enthusiasm and conviction.
- **Earth** (Taurus, Virgo, Capricorn): trusts what is real, useful, built.
- **Air** (Gemini, Libra, Aquarius): understands through ideas, words, connection.
- **Water** (Cancer, Scorpio, Pisces): reads the room through feeling.

Three modes: the rhythm

- **Cardinal** (Aries, Cancer, Libra, Capricorn): starts things.
- **Fixed** (Taurus, Leo, Scorpio, Aquarius): holds and sustains.
- **Mutable** (Gemini, Virgo, Sagittarius, Pisces): adapts and transforms.

Every sign has a ruler — the planet that “owns” it. Aries: Mars · Taurus: Venus · Gemini: Mercury · Cancer: Moon · Leo: Sun · Virgo: Mercury · Libra: Venus · Scorpio: Mars and Pluto · Sagittarius: Jupiter · Capricorn: Saturn · Aquarius: Saturn and Uranus · Pisces: Jupiter and Neptune.

Scorpio, Aquarius and Pisces have two rulers: the old one and the modern one. The old one is often the better key. Aquarius under Saturn is less “quirky rebel“, more “builder of the system“.

— V —

Houses: the WHERE

The stage.

A house isn't a personality trait. It's a stage: the area of life where a planet plays out.

House	Area of life
1	You: first impression, body, how you start things
2	Money, possessions, talents you live from
3	Everyday talk, learning, siblings, neighbours, short trips
4	Home, family, roots, your private inner base
5	Creativity, play, romance, children, joy
6	Daily work, routines, health habits
7	Partnership, close one-on-ones, open rivals
8	Shared money, intimacy, crisis, what you inherit
9	Big questions, higher learning, faith, far travel
10	Career, reputation, the path you're seen on
11	Friends, groups, networks, hopes for the future
12	Retreat, the hidden, what works behind the scenes

Houses come in pairs that belong together: 1 and 7 (me and you), 4 and 10 (private and public), 2 and 8 (mine and ours).

Watch out for clichés: "2nd house = self-worth" and "8th house = sex and transformation" are modern readings, not the original meaning. Sometimes useful, but not the whole picture. At all.

— VI —

Aspects: how the planets talk

The conversations.

Aspects are angles between two planets. They tell you which parts of you cooperate, and which ones argue.

Aspect	Angle	What it feels like
Conjunction	0°	Fused. Two drives act as one, for better or worse.
Sextile	60°	An open door. Easy talent, but you have to walk through it.
Square	90°	Friction. Two needs block each other — and that tension pushes you to act.
Trine	120°	Flow. Comes naturally, so naturally you may not notice it.
Opposition	180°	A tug-of-war. Often you live one side and meet the other in other people.

Orb = how close it is. An aspect rarely hits the exact angle. The closer two planets are to it, the louder the conversation. Sun and Moon get the widest room, the slow outer planets the least.

Hard isn't bad. Squares and oppositions are where people grow the most, because they can't be ignored. Trines are gifts that often stay unused.

There are more aspects than these five, such as the quincunx (150°) or the semi-square (45°). Here we keep to the five major ones. But the others can matter just as much when they are read properly and professionally.

Don't read an aspect as a formula. Cookbook lines like "planet A square planet B means X" leave out the most important part. An aspect never connects two planets in general. It connects two exact degrees, and each degree has its own theme. The aspect tells you how those two themes talk to each other. Two people with the same aspect can live completely different conversations.

— VII —

The level most charts never reach: the degree

Same sign. 30 shapes.

Here's what most astrology skips.

Every sign has 30 degrees. Two people with "Sun in Taurus" can be born almost a month apart — and live that sign in completely different shapes.

Each degree has its own theme. And each theme can show up in two ways:

- **Still growing:** the shadow form. The pattern runs you.
- **Grown into it:** the integrated form. You run the pattern.

Example: Sun at Taurus 1°

Still growing: Doubts every honest wish in case something better comes along, and hides in safe routines.

Grown into it: Expresses who they are spontaneously, acts on what they truly want, and stays loyal to one aim.

In real life:

- **Before:** leaves the job offer unanswered for weeks, in case a better one shows up.
- **After:** says yes to the offer that felt right at once, and figures out the hard parts as they come.

Notice: the shadow isn't a flaw. It's the same energy, not yet trusted.

And it works the same way for every other planet. Mars stands for how you go after what you want. Mars in Aries sounds like one thing: charge in, fight, win. The degree shows how different it can be:

- **Mars at Aries 21°** goes looking for the strongest opponent, to find out what it's made of. *Still growing:* fights anyone who limits it, and wastes strength on battles that don't matter. *Grown into it:* seeks out the toughest challenge and grows with each one.
- **Mars at Aries 17°** gets its strength from retreat. *Still growing:* tries to please everyone and wears itself out, or pulls back until solitude turns lonely. *Grown into it:* steps back when the world drains it, stays true to itself, and acts from that calm.

Same sign, same planet. One enters the ring, the other leaves the room.

Now compare **Mars at Taurus 24°**. Classically, Mars in Taurus is called weak: slow,

steady, out of its element. But this degree is about raw aggression. *Still growing:* bulldozes over other people's feelings and savors every win over a rival. *Grown into it:* channels that aggression into discipline and leads firmly without losing empathy. Shown only this Mars, most classical astrologers would guess Aries.

The sign gives you the style. The degree tells you what is really going on.

— VIII —

Reading a chart in 5 steps

Layer by layer.

1. **Start with the Big Three.** Sun (who you're becoming), Moon (what you need), Ascendant (how you meet the world). Ask: do they pull in the same direction, or in three?
2. **Find the chart ruler.** That's the ruler of your Ascendant sign. Where it sits — sign and house — is where your life wants to go.
3. **Place the planets in their houses.** For each planet: what (planet) · how (sign) · where (house). One sentence each.
4. **Look at the tightest aspects.** Start with the closest ones, especially those touching Sun, Moon or the chart ruler. They're the loudest conversations. Read each one as a conversation between two degrees, not as a formula.
5. **Go to the degrees.** Sign tells you the style. The degree tells you the shape — and what it looks like grown up. All 360 are on astrostrip.com/degrees (how to look one up: last page).

Don't try to read everything at once. A chart is read in layers, not in one go.

— IX —

One chart, read step by step

A made-up example.

So you can see the method at work.

Leo Rising · Sun at Taurus 1° in the 10th · Moon in Pisces in the 8th · Mars at Scorpio 1° in the 4th, opposite the Sun

1. **Big Three:** Taurus Sun wants to build something solid and lasting. Pisces Moon needs closeness without walls. Leo Rising walks in warm and visible. Two of three are steady and soft, the Rising is loud.
2. **Chart ruler:** Leo is ruled by the Sun. The Sun sits in the 10th house: this life wants to be seen through its work.
3. **Houses:** Mars in the 4th: drive works around home and roots, often out of sight. Moon in the 8th: emotional safety comes from deep trust, not small talk.
4. **Tightest aspect:** Mars opposite Sun, exact. On the sign level, Taurus wants to keep and build, Scorpio wants depth and change. A tug-of-war between holding on and letting go. That's only the rough outline.
5. **Degrees:** Now it gets personal. The Sun at Taurus 1° is about acting on what you truly want, without the gap between wish and move. Its shadow: doubting every wish in case something better comes along. Mars at Scorpio 1° isn't the intense, controlling Mars the cliché expects. It's curiosity: the drive to leave the familiar for more life. In the 4th house, that means leaving where you come from.

Still growing: both sides chase "something better". The Sun waits for it and hides in safe routines, Mars runs after every new thing and never really chooses. Often one side gets lived and the other shows up in a restless partner.

Grown into it: curiosity shows the Sun what it really wants, and the Sun's loyalty to one aim makes Mars pick its paths with a clear head. Leaving home becomes a decision, not an escape.

The two exact degrees decide what this opposition is really about. Change one degree, and it's a different conversation.

— X —

Find your degree

Where to go from here.

You now know how a chart is built. That's the first step.

How to look up a degree:

1. Calculate your chart for free on astrostrip.com. The table shows every planet with its sign and degree.
2. Always go up to the next degree: drop the minutes and add one, even at 00′. Degrees count from 1 to 30, so Scorpio 20°58′ sits on **Scorpio 21**, Aries 10°00′ on **Aries 11**, and anything from 0°00′ to 0°59′ is degree 1.
3. Look it up on astrostrip.com/degrees: the theme of the degree, its shadow form and its grown form.
4. Put it together: the planet tells you *what* (Venus: love and values), the sign *how*, the house *where*, and the degree the exact shape it takes.

That gives you a first sketch of one planet. The real picture comes from all of them talking to each other.

Free on astrostrip.com:

- **Your exact Sun degree** — with its shadow form, its grown form and what it looks like in real life.
- **All 360 Sun degrees** to browse, every sign and every degree: astrostrip.com/degrees
- **Your Big Three** — Sun, Moon and Rising, calculated from your birth data.
- **Your week ahead** for your Sun degree.
- **Your whole chart**, calculated.

Want the degrees of your Moon, your Rising and every planet read together? Turn the page.

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— XI —

Want it done for you?

Your chart, stripped down by us.

This guide gets you started. Reading a whole chart takes practice: ten planets, twelve houses, dozens of aspects, and every one of them on its own degree. If you'd rather have it read for you, that's what the Strips are for. Each one is prepared for your chart alone and arrives as a PDF.

Mini Strip · 29 €

Your Big Three in depth: houses, their key aspects and the exact degrees of Rising, Sun and Moon. About 6 pages, in 5 working days.

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All 360 Sun degrees: astrostrip.com/degrees

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